Blood that is the life of souls (Diary, § 299). Where the image hangs, it asks of the one praying the one thing the whole devotion asks: trust.

The Church's approval. The Chaplet did not begin as an authorized liturgical practice. St. Faustina died in 1938, her Diary was for a time withheld while the Church examined it, and the examination concluded in the devotion's favour. Pope St. John Paul II beatified her in 1993 and canonized her on the Second Sunday of Easter, 30 April 2000, announcing on that day that the Second Sunday of Easter would be kept throughout the Church as Divine Mercy Sunday. Pope Francis opened the Jubilee of Mercy with the bull *Misericordiae Vultus* (2015), whose first sentence is the doctrine in brief: "Jesus Christ is the face of the Father's mercy."

The Diary. St. Faustina wrote her *Diary* at the direction of her confessors and superiors; it was published in Polish as *Miłosierdzie Boże w duszy mojej*, rendered in English as *Divine Mercy in My Soul*. The paragraph numbers cited in this leaflet are those of that standard edition, so that the words quoted here may be found and read in their full setting.

A Note on These Texts

- **What is devotion.** The Chaplet is a devotional practice, not a liturgical rite. The Church commends it and attaches indulgences to the Divine Mercy observance, but no one is bound to pray it, and its form is governed by custom and pastoral guidance.
- **What comes from private revelation.** The Chaplet, its promises, and the words quoted from St. Maria Faustina Kowalska (1905–1938) come from her *Diary*, *Divine Mercy in My Soul*. The Church canonized her in 2000 and approved the devotion, but private revelation adds nothing to the deposit of faith, and belief in it is not required for salvation.
- **What is doctrine.** That the Son of God offered His Body and Blood, Soul and Divinity to the Father for the sins of the world is the faith of the Church in the Holy Sacrifice of the Mass (Council of Trent, Session XXII; CCC 1362–1367).
- **What is discipline.** The plenary indulgence of Divine Mercy Sunday, granted under the usual conditions of confession, Communion, and prayer for the Pope, is governed by the Church's norms and may be modified; so too the three o'clock hour, which is commended rather than imposed.
- **Separate devotions.** The Hour of Great Mercy, Divine Mercy Sunday, and the Divine Mercy Novena each have their own prayers and their own place in the Church's year; the novena, for instance, runs from Good Friday to the vigil of Divine Mercy Sunday.

How to Pray the Chaplet of Divine Mercy

The Beads, the Prayers, and the Promises

Before You Begin

The Chaplet is prayed on the ordinary beads of a five-decade Rosary, in a repeating pattern of one large bead followed by ten small beads, five times over.

- **What you need:** a standard five-decade Rosary; any beads will serve that allow one large bead after ten small ones, five times over.
- **How long it takes:** about ten to twelve minutes at a steady pace.
- **Where to pray:** anywhere — at home, in a pew, in a chapel, beside a bed, on a journey; it may also be prayed before the Blessed Sacrament.
- **When to pray:** at any hour and for any intention — for yourself, for a sick person, for a dying person, for sinners, or for the whole world.
- **An image of Divine Mercy**, signed *"Jesus, I trust in You,"* may be placed where you pray; a candle is optional.

The Beads at a Glance

Part of the Rosary	What is prayed there
Crucifix	The Sign of the Cross
First large bead	The Our Father
Next small bead	The Hail Mary
Before the first decade	The Apostles' Creed
Large bead of each of the five decades	The Eternal Father prayer
Ten small beads of each decade	The decade prayer, ten times
After the fifth decade	The Closing Doxology, three times

The Order of Prayer, Step by Step

1. **Begin at the crucifix.** Make the **Sign of the Cross**.
2. **(Optional)** Recite the **Optional Opening Prayers** below — St. Faustina's Prayer for Sinners, the prayer *"You expired, Jesus,"* and the invocation of the Blood and Water said three times.
3. **On the first large bead**, pray the **Our Father**.
4. **On the next small bead**, pray the **Hail Mary**.
5. **Before the first decade**, pray the **Apostles' Creed**.
6. **On the large bead of the first decade**, pray the **Eternal Father** prayer.
7. **On each of the ten small beads**, pray the **decade prayer** once.

world, and particularly for poor sinners; for at that moment mercy was opened wide for every soul." (Diary, § 1572)

Notes for the One Praying

- **The Chaplet is a form of reparation.** Its heart is the offering of the Body and Blood, Soul and Divinity of Jesus Christ to God the Father, in atonement for the sins of the whole world. The words are few; the offering is the whole work of the Passion.
- **Repetition is the point.** Ten times the same aspiration on the small beads is not tedium but trust, and each repetition is a separate petition for mercy. Pray it slowly enough to mean it.
- **The whole world is in every petition.** Both the Eternal Father prayer and the decade prayer name *"the whole world."* Do not narrow them to a private need alone.
- **The beads may be held and turned as at the Rosary**, or simply laid on a table or held in the folded hands; the devotion does not depend on a particular way of counting.
- **The body may pray too.** A modest posture — kneeling, sitting, standing — may be kept, and a slight bow made on the large beads. None of this is prescribed.
- **The Chaplet may be prayed in community**, one voice leading and the assembly responding, and is customarily joined to the Rosary in many parishes.
- **The Hours of the Passion.** Our Lord asked that the Chaplet be accompanied by meditation on His Passion — the Stations of the Cross, adoration before the Blessed Sacrament, or a brief meditation on the wounds and the Blood — especially at three o'clock in the afternoon.
- **An Eastern Catholic note.** The Chaplet is a Latin-Rite devotion, though it is widely loved in the Eastern Catholic Churches. Eastern Catholics may make the Sign of the Cross with the Eastern formula and add an Eastern-style introductory prayer or the Trisagion.

The History of the Devotion

At Płock in Poland, in February 1931, St. Faustina recorded a vision of Christ with rays of light streaming from His Heart, and heard the request that an image be painted with the inscription *"Jesus, I trust in You."* The two rays, she wrote, "denote Blood and Water" — the pale ray the water that makes souls righteous, the red ray the

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For Jesus is our Hope:
through His merciful Heart, as through an open gate,
we pass through to Heaven.
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When to Pray the Chaplet

At any hour. The Chaplet may be prayed at any time of the day or night, for any intention.

At the Hour of Mercy, three o'clock in the afternoon. Our Lord asked St. Faustina that the Chaplet be prayed especially at the hour of His death on the cross, promising: *"In this hour you can obtain everything for yourself and for others for the asking; it was the hour of grace for the whole world — mercy triumphed over justice"* (Diary, § 1572). At that hour the Church also commends the Stations of the Cross, adoration before the Blessed Sacrament, or a brief meditation on the Passion.

For the dying. Our Lord promised that when the Chaplet is recited at the bedside of a dying person, His mercy envelops the soul and His anger is placated (Diary, § 1565, § 687).

For the faithful departed. The Chaplet may be offered for those who died in God's grace but are not yet perfectly purified — a prayer of suffrage within the communion of saints (CCC 1030–1032).

On Divine Mercy Sunday, the Second Sunday of Easter, the Church keeps the day on which our Lord asked that the whole world be reminded of His mercy, and grants a plenary indulgence under the usual conditions of confession, Communion, and prayer for the Pope.

The Promises of Our Lord

These are our Lord's words as St. Faustina recorded them. They are private revelation, and the Church's approval of the devotion does not make them a contract: the graces of the Chaplet are bound to **trust** in God's mercy, to **active love of neighbour** in the works of mercy, and to the **state of sanctifying grace** — the reception of the Sacraments of Confession and Holy Communion, especially worthily on Divine Mercy Sunday.

> *"Say unceasingly the chaplet that I have taught you. Whoever will recite it will receive great mercy at the hour of death." (Diary, § 687)*

> *"The souls that say this chaplet will be embraced by My mercy during their lifetime and especially at the hour of death." (Diary, § 754)*

> *"As often as you hear the clock strike the third hour, immerse yourself completely in My mercy, adoring and glorifying it; invoke its omnipotence for the whole*

8. **On the large bead of the second decade**, repeat the **Eternal Father** prayer, then the decade prayer ten times more. Repeat this pattern for the third, fourth and fifth decades.
9. **After the fifth decade**, recite the **Closing Doxology** three times.
10. **(Optional)** Recite the **Optional Closing Prayers**, then make the Sign of the Cross.

The Sign of the Cross

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In the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.
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Optional Opening Prayers

St. Faustina's Prayer for Sinners — recorded in her Diary, § 72.

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O Jesus, eternal Truth, our Life,
I call upon You and I beg Your mercy for poor sinners.
O sweetest Heart of my Lord, full of pity and unfathomable mercy,
I plead with You for poor sinners.
O Most Sacred Heart, Fount of Mercy
from which gush forth rays of inconceivable graces upon the entire human
race,
I beg of You light for poor sinners.
O Jesus, be mindful of Your own bitter Passion
and do not permit the loss of souls
redeemed at so dear a price of Your most precious Blood.
O Jesus, when I consider the great price of Your Blood,
I rejoice at its immensity,
for one drop alone would have been enough for the salvation of all
sinners.
Although sin is an abyss of wickedness and ingratitude,
the price paid for us can never be equalled.
Therefore, let every soul trust in the Passion of the Lord,
and place its hope in His mercy.
God will not deny His mercy to anyone.
Heaven and earth may change,
but God's mercy will never be exhausted.
Oh, what immense joy burns in my heart
when I contemplate Your incomprehensible goodness, O Jesus!
I desire to bring all sinners to Your feet
that they may glorify Your mercy throughout endless ages.
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Opening Prayer

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You expired, Jesus, but the source of life gushed forth for souls,
and the ocean of mercy opened up for the whole world.
O Fount of Life, unfathomable Divine Mercy,
envelop the whole world and empty Yourself out upon us.
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The Blood and the Water — three times.

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O Blood and Water, which gushed forth from the Heart of Jesus
as a fount of mercy for us, I trust in You!
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The Our Father

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Our Father, who art in heaven,
hallowed be Thy name;
Thy kingdom come;
Thy will be done on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread;
and forgive us our trespasses
as we forgive those who trespass against us;
and lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil. Amen.
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The Hail Mary

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Hail Mary, full of grace, the Lord is with thee;
blessed art thou among women,
and blessed is the fruit of thy womb, Jesus.
Holy Mary, Mother of God,
pray for us sinners,
now and at the hour of our death. Amen.
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The Apostles' Creed

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I believe in God, the Father almighty,
Creator of heaven and earth,
and in Jesus Christ, His only Son, our Lord,
who was conceived by the Holy Spirit,
born of the Virgin Mary,
suffered under Pontius Pilate,
was crucified, died and was buried;
He descended into hell;
on the third day He rose again from the dead;
He ascended into heaven,
and is seated at the right hand of God the Father almighty;
from there He will come to judge the living and the dead.
I believe in the Holy Spirit,
the holy catholic Church,
the communion of saints,
the forgiveness of sins,
the resurrection of the body,
and life everlasting. Amen.
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The Eternal Father Prayer (Large Bead)

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Eternal Father,
I offer You the Body and Blood, Soul and Divinity
of Your dearly beloved Son, our Lord Jesus Christ,
in atonement for our sins and those of the whole world.
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The Decade Prayer (Small Beads)

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For the sake of His sorrowful Passion,
have mercy on us and on the whole world.
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The Closing Doxology (Three Times)

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Holy God, Holy Mighty One, Holy Immortal One,
have mercy on us and on the whole world.
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Optional Closing Prayers

Prayer of Entrustment

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Eternal God, in whom mercy is endless
and the treasury of compassion inexhaustible,
look kindly upon us and increase Your mercy in us,
that in difficult moments we might not despair nor become despondent,
but with great confidence submit ourselves to Your holy will,
which is Love and Mercy itself. Amen.
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Alternative Closing Prayer, recorded in the Diary, § 1570.

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O Greatly Merciful God, Infinite Goodness,
today all mankind calls out from the abyss of its misery to Your mercy –
to Your compassion, O God;
and it is with its mighty voice of misery that it cries out.
Gracious God, do not reject the prayer of this earth's exiles!
O Lord, Goodness beyond our understanding,
Who are acquainted with our misery through and through,
and know that by our own power we cannot ascend to You,
we implore You: anticipate us with Your grace
and keep on increasing Your mercy in us,
that we may faithfully do Your holy will
all through our life and at death's hour.
Let the omnipotence of Your mercy shield us
from the darts of our salvation's enemies,
that we may with confidence, as Your children,
await Your final coming – that day known to You alone.
And we expect to obtain everything promised us by Jesus
in spite of all our wretchedness.
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